

WEEKLY BUSINESS SESSION – August 5, 2026

9:00 a.m. – Anne Basker Auditorium
600 N.W. Sixth Street, Grants Pass, OR 97526

Present: Ron Smith, Chair-Commissioner; Colene Martin, Vice-Chair-Commissioner; Gary Richardson, Commissioner; Nikole Guzman, Recorder

These are meeting minutes only. Only text enclosed in quotation marks reports a speaker's exact words.

Pursuant to notice through the media and in conformance with the Public Meeting Law, Ron Smith, Chair, called the meeting to order at 9:00 a.m. followed by the Pledge of Allegiance.

Items discussed were as follows:

1. CALL MEETING TO ORDER:

Pursuant to notice through the media and in conformance with the Public Meeting Law, Ron Smith, Chair, called the meeting to order at 9:00 a.m., followed by the Pledge of Allegiance.

2. DECLARE A POTENTIAL CONFLICT OF INTEREST:

Commissioners Richardson, Martin, and Smith each declared no potential conflicts of interest.

3. ADMINISTRATIVE ACTION(S) IN CONSIDERATION OF:

a. Community Development Block Grant (CDBG) Housing Rehabilitation Grant Contract 2025 - #H25012 - Approval of Conflict of Interest and Contract

Helene Lulich, Property Manager, presented the 2025 Community Development Block Grant Housing Rehabilitation Grant Contract. Josephine County had been awarded \$500,000 through the State of Oregon to assist approximately 20 to 25 low-income homeowners with eligible home repairs in areas of the County outside the City of Grants Pass.

Ms. Lulich explained that Legal Counsel had requested a conflict-of-interest exception from the State because of Chad Hansen's prior involvement with the County Budget Committee and the County's use of Home Bridging as the subrecipient. The State approved the requested exception, allowing the County to proceed with the grant and related subrecipient agreement.

b. Subrecipient Agreement between Josephine County and Home Bridging for the 2025 Housing Repair and Rehabilitation Program

Austin Hansen of Home Bridging described the prior housing-rehabilitation work completed for Josephine County and the anticipated work under the new grant. He reported that the prior County program completed repairs at 21 homes, including roof repairs, septic work, well-pump systems, ADA-accessibility ramps, manufactured-home seismic tie-down work, and other repairs. Licensed subcontractors were used when required.

Mr. Hansen stated that the program had received strong demand and maintained a waiting list of more than 50 applicants. Outreach had included newspapers, social media, and direct contact with potential applicants. Commissioners requested that future program information identify projects by ZIP code to help show the geographic distribution of assistance throughout Josephine County.

c. Resolution No. 2026-031; In the Matter of Referring to Josephine County Voters at the November 3, 2026, Election a Measure for Renewal of Adult Jail and Juvenile Detention Five-Year Local Option Tax

Legal Counsel Wally Hicks reviewed the proposed five-year local option tax. He explained that voters originally approved the levy in 2017 and later renewed it at the same rate of \$0.93 per \$1,000 of assessed value to support the adult jail and juvenile detention. The existing levy expires June 30, 2027.

Mr. Hicks explained that, because of increased operating costs, the current \$0.93 rate was not projected to fully fund both programs throughout another five-year term. The proposed language contemplated fully funding the adult jail while using a portion of the levy, together with other funding sources, to support juvenile detention services and retain capacity for up to 14 youth. The Board discussed the need for clear ballot language and the statutory deadline for submitting the measure to the County Clerk.

Chair Smith stated that he did not want the Board to make a decision on the resolution before receiving additional public input. Legal Counsel confirmed that the Board could continue the discussion and make revisions before the filing deadline.

4. REQUESTS/COMMENTS FROM CITIZENS:

(Each person was given three (3) minutes to speak.)

Jay Merideth, Josephine County, submitted written comments that were read into the record by Chair Smith. Mr. Merideth supported a simple renewal of the levy at the existing \$0.93 rate without a tax increase. He cited historical underspending, existing fund balances, and the County General Fund balance as reasons to retain the current rate while allowing additional time to evaluate future funding needs for the adult jail and juvenile detention.

Stephen Fitch, Josephine County, addressed the Board regarding his concerns with County government, law enforcement, and the judiciary. He requested increased oversight and accountability.

Thomas Blankenhorn, Josephine County, described ongoing disputes with neighbors and dogs, alleged property damage and criminal activity, and concerns regarding responses he had received from law-enforcement and other governmental agencies. He stated that he had attempted to contact the Commissioners regarding those matters and requested additional attention to his concerns.

Gayle Gasso, Grants Pass, asked how the County would address the Home Bridging conflict-of-interest exception if Chad Hansen were elected County Commissioner.

Mark Jones, Josephine County, addressed the proposed jail and juvenile detention levy. He suggested consideration of a \$0.99 rate to provide additional support for juvenile justice and requested clear ballot language regarding future funding needs and the possibility of other revenue measures.

Judy Aherns, Josephine County, spoke about education, literacy, juvenile justice, and the relationship between educational outcomes and future involvement in the justice system. She also thanked firefighters for their work during fire season.

BOARD MAY REVIEW PUBLIC COMMENTS/QUESTIONS:

Commissioner Richardson made a motion to approve the Community Development Block Grant (CDBG) Housing Rehabilitation Grant Contract 2025 - #H25012 - Approval of Conflict of Interest and Contract. Commissioner Martin seconded the motion. Upon roll call: Commissioner Richardson - Yes; Commissioner Martin - Yes; Commissioner Smith - Yes. Motion carried 3-0.

Commissioner Richardson made a motion to approve the Subrecipient Agreement between Josephine County and Home Bridging for the 2025 Housing Repair and Rehabilitation Program. Commissioner Martin seconded the motion. Upon roll call: Commissioner Richardson - Yes; Commissioner Martin - Yes; Commissioner Smith - Yes. Motion carried 3-0.

Chair Smith called for a motion on Resolution No. 2026-031. No motion was made. The Board tabled Resolution No. 2026-031 for further discussion and additional public input.

5. APPROVAL OF CONSENT CALENDAR:

a. Minutes (Draft minutes are available for viewing in the Board's Office)

General Discussion - July 27, 2026

KAJO Radio - July 28, 2026

Admin Workshop - July 28, 2026

Weekly Business Session - July 29, 2026

Legal Counsel Update - July 30, 2026

General Discussion - July 30, 2026

General Discussion - July 30, 2026

Commissioner Martin made a motion to approve the Consent Calendar. Commissioner Richardson seconded the motion. Upon roll call: Commissioner Richardson - Yes; Commissioner Martin - Yes; Commissioner Smith - Yes. Motion carried 3-0.

6. OTHER: (ORS 192.640(1))

No additional matters were introduced.

7. ANNOUNCEMENTS: MATTERS FROM COMMISSIONERS:

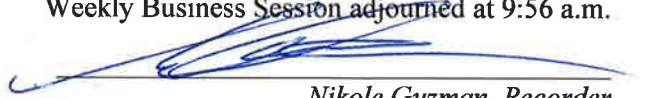
Commissioner Richardson discussed the forecast for triple-digit temperatures and referenced public information regarding signs of heat exhaustion and heat stroke and steps to assist individuals experiencing heat-related illness. He

encouraged the public to remain hydrated and take precautions during extreme heat.

Commissioner Martin thanked Recreation Director Tamra Martin, Fairgrounds staff, youth participants, families, and volunteers for their work on the Josephine County Fair. She stated that the Fair was well attended and successful and recognized the significant effort required to produce the event.

Chair Smith reiterated the extreme-heat warning and encouraged residents to stay hydrated, avoid excessive sun exposure, and exercise extreme caution with fire during fire season.

Weekly Business Session adjourned at 9:56 a.m.


Nikole Guzman, Recorder